

The Fedora 12 Review

Fedora 12 has many—that's actually, MANY—enhancements. In this article, we'll only take a look at it from an 'everyday' desktop user's point of view.

This is

"This is *Constantine*, John Constantine, a "hole," was Keanu Reeves' punchline in the 2005 Hollywood flick *Constantine*, every time he freed a human soul possessed by a daemon. Well, Fedora 12, which is codenamed Constantine, looks somewhat like the John Constantine, and its whole purpose is to free up the computer souls still infected with all those ugly (and slimy) viruses that just wouldn't let the computer act normally. The difference? Fedora's Constantine is here to free up the machines. And mind you, machines aren't always these evil entities that Hollywood sci-fi flicks would have you believe. We need them more than ever in the 21st century.

The background

I have a habit of going through the release notes while I download any OS. This helps me become aware of the changes beforehand, and also skim through the features that cater to my interests. And, unlike other distros, Fedora has always been very good at documenting most of the essential changes in detail under the release notes. For Fedora 12, it's at <http://docs.fedoraproject.org/release-notes/f12/en-US/html-single/>.

Here are some of the changes that interested me as a user:

- Grub can now read ext4 partitions, and

thus, there is no need to create a separate ext3 partition for */boot/* as was the case in Fedora 11.

- All packages for x86 processors are now optimised for the i86 variants—what 99 per cent of us are running anyway. This is a welcome change considering apps should run faster now.
- For all those who use a more-than-one monitor set-up, the desktop should span across the monitors, instead of duplicating the same desktop on all the monitors. [I don't use such a set-up so I couldn't test this feature.]
- More Web cams are now supported out of the box. [I don't use Web cams either.]
- The introduction of a newbie-friendly bug reporting tool called ABRT, which replaces Bug-Buddy and kerneloops. Quoting the release notes, "In contrast to Bug-Buddy, it can catch segmentation faults in any binary, not just GTK+ applications." [Unfortunately, nothing crashed on my system as of this writing and thus I couldn't check the usability of this tool either;-)]
- *initrd* is replaced by a distro-independent system called Dracut. [An article titled 'Bootstrapping Fedora 12', discusses this briefly.]
- The Yum Presto plug-in is enabled by default. Fedora 11 introduced this as an optional package that could retrieve